The Women of Lockerbie

By Deborah Breevort

BILL: **(Pg 65)** [Adam's] body was never found. He's still out here somewhere.

MADELINE: **(PG 22-23)** I can feel him. If only I could find him! If only I could find some *part* of him. *A bone.* The bone from his *chin.* I would know it if I saw it! He had such a *strong... firm..* chin...And what I would give to talk to him. Even if it was only to say "Pick up your socks!" If only I could find him... **(PG 24)** there's got to be something of him somewhere!

INTRODUCTION

When Pan Am Flight 103 exploded over Lockerbie, Scotland on December 21, 1988, it was carrying 35 Syracuse University students home from a semester spent studying abroad. The explosion, caused by a terrorist bombing, resulted in the deaths of everyone on board and 11 people of the town of Lockerbie. It was the largest terrorist attack in the history of the UK.

In this fictious account, a mother from New Jersey travels to Lockerbie, looking for her son's remains. This is her story . . . The Women of Lockerbie by Deborah Brevort.

NOTE: *THE WOMEN OF LOCKERBIE is loosely inspired by a true story, although the characters and situations in the play are purely fictional. Written in the structure of a Greek tragedy, it is a poetic drama. Although lines in this cutting are attributed to various characters, the final product may sound amazingly like a monologue.*

MADELINE: **(PG 29-30)** I was in the kitchen baking a pie for Adam. a pumpkin pie, to welcome him home. The TV was on. I listen to it when I'm cooking. I sprinkle flour on the counter and roll out the pie dough. I roll it once in each direction, like this... *(she rolls)* the way my mother taught me. And then, Ted Koppel comes on the air. I know immediately that something is wrong. He said:

BILL: "We interrupt this program..."

MADELINE: I thought, oh, dear, something awful has happened. What a shame. And so close to Christmas. I grab more flour and sprinkle it. I roll the crust. I hear...

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BILL: "Pam Am 103 was last seen in a fireball over Scotland."

MADELINE: I double over into the kitchen counter. My face presses into the pie dough. I cannot stand up. I grope the counter for something to hold on to. I reach for the handle on the refrigerator -- pull myself up. And there in front of me is a note held by a magnet that says "Adam. 7PM. JFK. Pam Am 103." *(She sinks to the ground, overcome with grief)* I live in New Jersey! I have two cars in the driveway! This was not supposed to happen to me!

CHORAL DIALOGUE: Multiple women speak to the audience (Pg 32-33)

WOMAN 1: You think the worst can't happen.

WOMAN 2: You think that it won't.

WOMAN 1: But then, one day, it does.

OLIVE: The poor soul on television is suddenly you. Death is a guest whose visit is short. When it comes to your house it never stays

WOMAN 1: But, grief...

OLIVE: Grief is a guest who stays too long. Its visit turns from days,

WOMAN 2: into weeks,

WOMAN 1: into months,

OLIVE: into years.

WOMAN 2: It takes over your house and will not leave. Wherever you go it follows.

WOMAN 1: Whatever you do it watches.

OLIVE: It hovers behind you, looking over your shoulder so you cannot forget that it's there. **(Pg 26-27)** Grief needs to talk

BILL: She goes over and over the moment I heard the news. Over and over the moment of his death. I've stopped listening. I can't take it anymore.

MADELINE: **(PG 28)** It's all right if you think I'm crazy, because I am. I roam the hills looking for my son's body. Only a crazy person would do that....

OLIVE: . . . or a mother.

MADELINE: I'm not a mother anymore... **(PG 40-42)** I never should have let him study in London. He was too young. Much too young to go so far away from home. I should have made him wait for a year. I should have been more firm. And why did I choose Pan Am over Delta? There were two boxes on the application form! Why didn't I...*check the box for Delta?* *(pause)* And I should have let him stay an extra day with his friends! But I said, "No, I want you home for Christmas. I want you home for the party. You need to hang the Christmas lights for your father." *(pause)* Oh God... *(pause)* And why did I plan the party for Friday? I should have planned it for Saturday! If I had planned the party for Saturday he wouldn't have been on that plane. He never would have died. He could have flown on Delta! - I could have said "Yes, you can come home whenever you want!" I should have hung the Christmas lights! I could have gotten on that ladder myself!

CHORAL DIALOGUE: Multiple women speak to the audience (PG 42-44)

OLIVE: Our lives are made of choices. Hundreds of little choices that determine our fate, each with a consequence we cannot see.

WOMAN 1: You check the box for Delta and your son lives.

WOMAN 2: You check the box for Pam Am and he dies.

WOMAN 1: Choices,

WOMAN 2: such little choices...

WOMAN 1: Sometimes I wonder if the choices you make are yours at all...

WOMAN 2: Or if they're made by something else Something greater, like God.

WOMAN 1: Sometimes it seems that these things are fated,

WOMAN 2: meant to happen.

MADELINE: **(PG 46-47)** I was a good mother! And a good wife! And a good neighbor! I made cookies for the bake sale! I gave money to the swim team! I remembered birthdays! When someone got sick, I made chicken soup! And this is how I'm repaid?

BILL: It's not fair. Life's. Not. Fair. At some point you have to accept that. You have to move on.

MADELINE: Move on? To what? What is there to move on to?

BILL: **(PG 48 – 50)** I had to return his Christmas presents back to the mall. Do you know what that was like? What do you say to the sales clerk? What do you say to the 16-year old school girl standing behind the counter at JC Penney's who smiles at you and asks "Why are you returning the sweater?" What do you say to someone so young and innocent? "This was for my son, but he died?" "He was blown to bits by a bomb?" What do you say to the pretty young girl with red and green ribbons in her hair? *(pause)* I just said... "My son doesn't need it anymore". And then I breathe a sigh of relief because I think I've gotten through it. But I haven't. Oh no! It doesn't stop there. I go to the next store, to return the Nikes. And to the next store to return the pajamas. And the next store to return the bathrobe and the blue jeans and the bike helmet. *(pause)* I go to six stores before the day is through. I have that same conversation in every single place. *(pulling out a wallet to examine the pictures)*

MADELINE: **(PG 82-84)** Adam? How quickly you passed... One moment here. The next moment there. Living, dead. Living, dead. Dead. Dead, dead, dead. What is it like to be dead? What was it like when you crossed the line and passed to the other side? Where you drinking a coke? Taking a nap? Or were you talking...? Having a nice conversation with the woman right beside you? Mrs. Corcoran. Yes, Doris Corcoran. She was a teacher from Syracuse University. Were you talking about London? Christmas? College? Changing your major to math? And what... did you *"do"* the moment it happened...? Did you grab Mrs. Corcoran's hand? Close your eyes and pray? Or did it happen too fast for any of that? Adam... *What happened next?* What did you do? Where did you go? You must have gone *somewhere*... *(grief turns to a growing anger that builds to a crescendo)*

(PG 44-45) If I ever meet his killers I will inflict on them the measure of pain they have brought to me. They should suffer! Pain is a gentle word to describe what I would do to them if I ever got the chance! I want justice! I won't find peace until there is justice. Those men killed [my] son! They killed 270 people! They destroyed our lives!

CHORAL DIALOGUE: Multiple women speak to the audience (PG 51-52)

WOMAN 1: There's an order in the world. An order behind the chaos and the violence.

WOMAN 2: And there's a purpose. If the sun never set, we would find no beauty in the sunrise.

WOMAN 1: If the night was full of light, we would not see the stars.

OLIVE: And if hatred never pierced our hearts, we would not know the power of love.

WOMAN 1: They are given to us so we learn and grow. You have to trust in this. Trust.

OLIVE: And believe that behind the suffering of the world, there is a purpose to everything.

BILL: **(PG 52-53)** I want to believe that. I want nothing more than to believe that this happened for a reason. But I can't. I just...can't. To believe that would mean that Adam died just so that I could learn and grow. And that's not true. There is no lesson so important that it was worth the price of his life. To believe that would mean that I am at the center of the universe and that all things happen for my benefit. And they don't. The events of the world... the horrors... *just happen*. And they happen for *no reason*. The only thing you can do is accept that and carry on the best you can. Just accept the suffering that comes to you and find some way to keep going. **(PG 86)** Why do [you/I] hold on to [your/my] grief so hard?

MADELINE: It's the only thing I have left to hold on to!

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2006 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier – MS
2017 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
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